

The Shadow Puppet Theater

Easy start · Indoors · Grown-up nearby · Ages 5–9 · 30 min

Brought to you by Zech — “One sheet of paper. A hundred possibilities.”

Cut paper puppets, find one lamp, and discover you can make a mouse the size of a bear.

WHAT YOU NEED

- Thick paper or card
- Safety scissors
- Straws or lolly sticks
- Tape
- A lamp and a plain wall or a sheet

BEFORE YOU START

A grown-up positions the lamp. Bulbs get hot.
Cut with the scissors pointing away from your hand.

How to make it

- 1 Draw two characters in profile, side-on, with clear outlines. Shadows lose all the detail inside.
- 2 Cut them out and tape a straw to the back of each one.
- 3 Set the lamp up facing a plain wall, and stand your screen or sheet between them if you have one.
- 4 Hold a puppet close to the wall. Look at its size. Now move it towards the lamp and look again.
- 5 Use that discovery in a story: the small character grows huge when it steps forward.
- 6 Perform the story with the lights off for anybody who will sit down.

TALK ABOUT IT

What happened to the edges of the shadow when you moved the puppet, and why do you think that was?

TRY THIS TOO

Cut small holes in the puppets so tiny points of light shine through as eyes or stars.

DID YOU KNOW? · COLOR & LIGHT

Light travels in straight lines, so blocking it makes a shadow. Light does not bend around your puppet. It goes straight, which is why the shape it cannot pass through appears on the wall. Move the puppet closer to the lamp and it blocks more of the light, so the shadow grows.